CSIS AUSTRALIA CHAIR

Australia Daily Brief

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RE: NZ election deadlocked, Opportunity a kingmaker · Taiwan to shut PNG office over Chinese pressure · Defence to sell 67 sites, Tasmania loses live-fire ranges · Albanese may meet Trump at Quad · Fiji parliament ratifies Vuvale Union treaty

ASX 200	AUD/USD	NZX 50	NZD/USD
9,021	0.6868	13,998	0.5548
+1.27%	-2.29%	+1.46%	-1.37%

IN THIS ISSUE Top Stories · Overnight · Stat · AUKUS · Pacific · New Zealand · Canberra · Markets · Documents · Upcoming · The Wire · Analysis

TODAY AT A GLANCE

1. New Zealand's National-ACT-NZ First bloc holds a two-seat lead with 95 percent of voting places counted, but Victoria University political scientist Tom Jamieson says a government is unlikely to form before Christmas.
2. Taiwan will close its Papua New Guinea office over Chinese pressure, days after a PNG minister credited Beijing's support for the country's K200 billion growth target.
3. Fiji's parliament approved the Fiji-Australia Vuvale Union and the Ocean of Peace Alliance Veitacini Treaty, locking in the bilateral framework Canberra has pursued since 2023.

TOP STORIES

NZ-POLITICS

New Zealand election deadlocked as counting nears completion

With 95 percent of voting places counted, the National-ACT-NZ First bloc clings to a majority by two seats over Labour. **Tom Jamieson**, a senior lecturer in political science at Victoria University of Wellington, told the ABC that official results and special votes will not be finalised for roughly three weeks and that a coalition is unlikely before Christmas. The minor party Opportunity has emerged as a possible kingmaker, and National is expected to lose senior ministers.

per ABC News (Stephen Dziedzic): "Live: Parliamentary newcomers Opportunity potential kingmakers in tight NZ election" · also Reuters

CHINA-PACIFIC

Taiwan to close Papua New Guinea office, cites Chinese pressure

Taiwan will close its representative office in Papua New Guinea, blaming pressure from Beijing. The decision lands days after a PNG minister credited Chinese support as underpinning the country's *K200 billion* economy target. Three Pacific Islands Forum members retain formal diplomatic relations with Taipei: the Marshall Islands, Palau, and Tuvalu.

per Nikkei Asia: "Taiwan to close Papua New Guinea office, blames Chinese pressure"

AU-DEFENSE

Defence to sell sixty-seven sites, stripping Tasmania of live-fire ranges

The Department of Defence will sell sixty-seven sites nationwide to raise about *$1.8 billion*, among them Tasmania's two live fire ranges, the 5,500-hectare Stony Head Training Area near Launceston and the Buckland Military Training Area. **Peter Williams**, a veteran and secretary of the Launceston RSL, said Stony Head is one of the best amphibious training beaches in Australia. The sales will leave the state without a live fire training area.

per ABC News: "Inside the $3 billion battle over defence real estate"

PACIFIC-DIPLOMACY

Fiji's parliament approves Vuvale Union treaty with Australia

Fiji's parliament approved the Fiji-Australia Vuvale Union and the Ocean of Peace Alliance Veitacini Treaty, Fijivillage reported. Ratification clears the final domestic hurdle for the bilateral framework, and comes while Suva's parliament is also consumed by a contested Constitution Amendment Bill.

per Fijivillage: "Parliament approves Fiji–Australia Vuvale Union and Ocean of Peace Alliance Veitacini Treaty"

OVERNIGHT

AU-FOREIGN-POLICY

Albanese urges Iran de-escalation after US midterms · Bloomberg

Anthony Albanese called for de-escalation with Iran in the aftermath of the US midterm elections, Bloomberg reported. The appeal follows Washington's offer this week of a reward of up to *$US20 million* and possible relocation for information on Iran's nuclear program, its facilities, equipment, and scientific personnel.

US-AUSTRALIA

Albanese in line for a Quad leaders meeting before year's end · Guardian AU politics

Anthony Albanese is expected to sit around a table with **Donald Trump**, India's **Narendra Modi**, and Japan's **Sanae Takaichi** before the end of the year, **Tom McIlroy** wrote, a prospect Albanese's advisers rated remote only weeks ago. The 2025 Quad talks due in India were quietly cancelled after a blow-up between Trump and Modi; the 2023 summit was also put off at short notice. The meeting would fall between COP31 in Antalya and a visit to China.

TRADE-ECONOMY

Australia's housing slump deepens as the RBA readies another rise · WSJ

The Wall Street Journal reported Australia's housing downturn is deepening as the Reserve Bank prepares a further increase in the cash rate. The RBA lifted rates this week for the fifth time in 2026, taking the cash rate to an eighteen-year high, according to ABC reporting.

AU-POLITICS

Ministers told to find savings as home battery subsidy comes under review · ABC News

Environment Minister **Murray Watt** said every minister has been told to find savings in their own portfolio before the mid-year budget update, while calling the home battery subsidy scheme "phenomenally successful". The prime minister declined to rule out means-testing the *$7.2 billion* program, under which around 600,000 batteries have been installed since 2025. The Coalition wants it scrapped as "unsafe and unaffordable".

TRADE-ECONOMY

Australian diesel inventory dips as the government flags uncertainty · Bloomberg

Australian diesel inventories fell, with the government flagging uncertainty over supply, Bloomberg reported. The figures land while Canberra remains under pressure over refined fuel imported from Russian crude, and with Brent at 98.32, down 6.16 percent on November 6.

TRADE-ECONOMY

International students reconsider Australia as the sector turns political · SMH

Prospective international students are having second thoughts about Australia as populism gains traction and student numbers become a political flashpoint, the Sydney Morning Herald reported. The university sector is worth *$54 billion*, making it one of the country's largest export industries.

STAT OF THE DAY

$1.8 billion

Target from Defence's sale of 67 sites

The sell-off will leave Tasmania without a live-fire training area, part of a $3 billion dispute over defence real estate.

ABC News

AUKUS WATCH

PILLAR 1 · POLITICO

Canberra independents to test AUKUS in Labor's capital heartland

Independent candidates will contest Labor-held seats in the Australian Capital Territory on an AUKUS platform, Politico reported, carrying the submarine debate into the government's safest urban territory. The push follows the crowd-funded inquiry led by **Peter Garrett** and **Chris Barrie** that called this week for the pact to be scrapped.

PACIFIC WIRE

REGIONAL · PACIFIC ISLAND TIMES

Pacific climate network tells COP31 negotiators not to lower ambition

The Pacific Islands Climate Action Network urged governments gathering in Antalya for COP31 to carry commitments made last month in Fiji and Tuvalu into the negotiating rooms. International policy lead **Sindra Sharma** said, "We cannot afford a COP that lowers ambition when the science demands greater urgency."

VANUATU · VANUATU DAILY POST

New Caledonian politician urges France to suspend cooperation with Vanuatu

New Caledonian politician **Nicolas Metzdorf** called on France to recall its ambassador from Vanuatu and suspend cooperation between the two countries if Port Vila continues to pursue its claim over Matthew and Hunter.

COOK ISLANDS · COOK ISLANDS NEWS

New Zealand sailors crew Cook Islands patrol boat in fisheries operation

Four Royal New Zealand Navy sailors assisted fisheries enforcement while crewing the Cook Islands Pacific Patrol Boat Te Kukupa II, a Guardian-class vessel operated by the Cook Islands Police Service Maritime Unit, during a multi-nation surveillance operation last month.

VANUATU · VANUATU DAILY POST

Second report on Vanuatu diplomatic passport sales goes to parliament

The Parliamentary Account Committee presented a second report on allegations of the sale of Vanuatu diplomatic passports to the Clerk of Parliament, **Maxime Banga**. The document arrives as Vanuatu's parliament prepares to debate a no-confidence motion.

PAPUA NEW GUINEA · PNG POST-COURIER

PNG police commissioner pauses cadet recruitment over regional imbalance

Commissioner of Police **David Manning** temporarily suspended the Officer Cadet recruitment process for the Royal Papua New Guinea Constabulary to review the underrepresentation of some provinces. The review will examine barriers facing applicants, including education and health requirements and difficulty obtaining supporting documents.

FIJI · FIJIVILLAGE

Civil society group questions extended restrictions before Fiji's election

The Citizens' Constitutional Forum body CDD questioned the Fijian government's decision to extend restrictions on civil society ahead of the general election, Fijivillage reported. The move comes as Unity Fiji names 23 proposed candidates for the poll.

VANUATU · PNG POST-COURIER

Vanuatu approves VT60 million for El Nino response

Vanuatu's Council of Ministers approved *VT60 million*, about $US1.1 million, to help provinces assess and respond to El Nino impacts, particularly water shortages.

FIJI · PNG POST-COURIER

Rabuka says Fiji has prepared for months as drought bites

Prime Minister **Sitiveni Rabuka** said the government has been preparing for the impact of prolonged dry weather for months, as communities across Fiji face water shortages linked to El Nino. The National Fire Authority warned separately that depleted water sources could undermine firefighting, having used about 1.088 million litres on structural fires between January and September.

COOK ISLANDS · COOK ISLANDS NEWS

Cyber safety workshops reach 140 people on Mangaia

A total of 140 people on Mangaia took part in cyber safety awareness workshops designed to help the community recognise and guard against online scams and threats.

SAMOA · SAMOA OBSERVER

Samoan police await updates on nationals detained in Vietnam

Samoa Police are waiting on further information about Samoan citizens detained in Vietnam, the Samoa Observer reported.

NEW ZEALAND

NZ-POLITICS · NYT ASIA PACIFIC

Cost of living drove New Zealand's vote, with no clear front-runner

Preliminary results showed no clear front-runner after a campaign dominated by economic concerns, the New York Times reported, placing the contest alongside a global pattern of voters punishing incumbents over prices.

NZ-POLITICS · FINANCIAL TIMES

The Financial Times calls it New Zealand's 'supermarket election'

The Financial Times framed the ballot as a "supermarket election", with grocery prices the dominant issue for voters choosing between **Christopher Luxon** and **Chris Hipkins**.

NZ-POLITICS · AFP

Polls close at 7pm with every vote counted by hand

Polling stations closed at 7pm after a day governed by strict election laws limiting media reporting and campaigning. New Zealand's mixed-member proportional system gives each voter a party vote and an electorate vote for a parliament of typically 120 seats, with all ballots counted by hand rather than machine.

CANBERRA POLITICS

AU-POLITICS · SMH FEDERAL POLITICS

Payman says Albanese offered her extra staff for her vote

Independent senator **Fatima Payman** said **Anthony Albanese** offered her additional staff in exchange for her vote during contentious Senate negotiations in the last term. The claim follows One Nation MP **David Farley**'s rejection a week ago of an unsolicited staffing offer, which he feared was an attempt to curry favour.

AU-POLITICS · ABC POLITICS

ABC analysis reads the US midterms as a warning for Labor

The ABC's political analysis argues the American result leaves the Albanese government no room for error in an era of cost-of-living pain, with the opposition having partly succeeded in linking government spending to this week's rate rise. Government figures looked "punch drunk" after the fifth increase of the year.

AU-POLITICS · ABC POLITICS

Pollster says Queensland Labor faces its greatest challenge in decades

Kos Samaras, director of the RedBridge Group, said Queensland Labor is in a tight contest with One Nation to be the state's second most popular party, facing both a popular LNP government and an insurgent right. Opposition Leader **Steven Miles** is attempting a return to the premiership not achieved since 1911, with none of Labor's 36 MPs having served in opposition before.

AU-POLITICS · ABC POLITICS

Scanlon Index finds more than 60 percent say social cohesion has worsened

The Scanlon Index of Social Cohesion found *more than 60 percent* of Australians believe cohesion has worsened in recent years, with the report's lead author, the ANU's **James O'Donnell**, attributing the decline to cost-of-living pressure and an unreliable global economy.

BUSINESS AND ECONOMY

TRADE-ECONOMY · THE AUSTRALIAN

Cannon-Brookes defends Atlassian AI strategy as shares plunge

Mike Cannon-Brookes defended Atlassian's artificial intelligence strategy after shares fell on a weak forecast, telling investors not to believe everything they read. The ASX 200 closed at 9,021, up 1.27 percent, on November 6.

PRIMARY DOCUMENTS

MINISTERIAL TRANSCRIPT · AU MINISTERIAL

Wong opens applications for Maitri grants on Australia-India ties

Foreign Minister **Penny Wong** announced that applications are open for Maitri grants to strengthen Australia-India ties. The program runs alongside the prospective Quad leaders meeting involving Australia, the United States, India, and Japan.

MINISTERIAL TRANSCRIPT · AU MINISTERIAL

Farrell addresses the European Australian Business Council

Trade Minister **Don Farrell** spoke at the European Australian Business Council reception and board dinner, the department published.

UPCOMING

NOV 25

Daniel Whippy's next appearance, Suva Magistrates Court

The Carpenters Fiji managing director's case over an amended 2018 fire investigation report continues, with trial dates tentatively set for April 19 to May 17, 2027.

NOV 2026

Official New Zealand election results and special vote count

Tom Jamieson told the ABC the exact balance of power will not be known until roughly three weeks after polling day.

NOV 2026

COP31 in Antalya, Türkiye

Pacific negotiators are pressing to hold the 1.5 degree threshold, and Anthony Albanese is expected to attend before a visit to China.

DEC 7

Christies Beach Magistrates Court appearance over alleged harassment of the SA Speaker

The case follows a run of harassment and stalking incidents involving Australian parliamentarians.

DEC 2026

Australian mid-year budget update (MYEFO)

Every minister has been told to find portfolio savings, with the $7.2 billion home battery subsidy under review.

THE WIRE

PACIFIC-DIPLOMACY

COOK ISLANDS NEWS

Australian First Nations experts hold environmental exchange in Cook Islands

Two Australian First Nations experts spent a week in meetings and cultural exchanges with Cook Islands communities, exploring shared approaches to environmental protection.

VANUATU DAILY POST

Vanuatu-Australia Community Grants Program to open applications

Communities across Vanuatu will soon be able to apply for grants of up to *VT4.7 million* under the Vanuatu-Australia Community Grants Program.

PACIFIC-POLITICS

FIJIVILLAGE

NFP assistant foreign minister says Fiji should not rush the Constitution Bill

National Federation Party MP and Assistant Minister for Foreign Affairs **Lenora Qereqeretabua** said more time is needed on the Constitution Amendment Bill, arguing Fiji should not replace an imposed constitution by imposing another. Defence Minister **Pio Tikoduadua** declined to say how he will vote.

US-AUSTRALIA

ABC NEWS

Half-Australian senator Jon Ossoff leads early 2028 Democratic polling

Georgia senator **Jon Ossoff**, who holds Australian ties, led an AtlasIntel poll of Democratic primary voters by less than one percentage point over **Alexandria Ocasio-Cortez**, the ABC reported. A year ago he did not register in presidential contender forecasts.

AU-DEFENSE

AUSTRALIAN DEFENCE MAGAZINE

Southern Launch leads the Varda W-8 capsule re-entry

South Australian company Southern Launch led the re-entry of the Varda W-8 capsule, Australian Defence Magazine reported.

ANALYSIS AND OPINION

AUSTRALIAN DEFENCE MAGAZINE

Video Summary - Bureaucracy drags Navy down, Ocius for Japan, and WIDA

Australian Defence Magazine's weekly video summary covers bureaucratic drag on the Navy, an Ocius sale to Japan, and WIDA.

Argument: Administrative process is slowing the Royal Australian Navy's capability delivery.

CSIS Australia Chair

AUSTRALIA DAILY BRIEF

Washington, D.C.

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